

# Understanding Online Child Sexual Exploitation

*A learning guide for parents, caregivers & educators*



## What Is Online Child Sexual Exploitation?

It covers a wide range of behaviours and situations — most commonly grooming, live-streamed abuse, exposure to child sexual abuse material, and coercing or blackmailing a child for sexual purposes. It is often assumed to involve only adults targeting children, but a growing share of exploitative material is shared through social media and produced by children themselves — sometimes called self-generated content, often beginning as 'sexting'.



## What It Can Look Like

- An adult engaging a child in sexual chat, or sending explicit images of themselves
- Exposing oneself to a child via live-stream or video call
- Asking a child to view pornographic images or videos
- Pressuring a child to perform sexual acts or share a sexual image
- Taking, making, sharing, or showing indecent images of children
- Children being coerced into producing and sharing their own explicit images ('self-generated' content)



## Warning Signs to Watch For

- Increased secrecy about online activity, contacts, or a new 'friend'
- Sudden mood or behaviour changes, or withdrawal from family
- Possessiveness over devices; hiding the screen when someone approaches
- Unexplained gifts, new apps, or unfamiliar online accounts
- Mature language or sexual knowledge beyond their years
- No single sign confirms exploitation — trust your instincts and stay curious, not accusatory



## BY THE NUMBERS (IWF, Annual Data & Insights Report 2025)

**63,044**

teens aged 14–17 appeared in confirmed abuse imagery

**33%**

of imagery of 14–17 year-olds was self-generated

**1 / 70s**

a report of suspected abuse material assessed every 70 seconds



## If Your Child Tells You

- Stay calm — your reaction shapes whether they come to you again
- Don't blame them; reassure them it is not their fault
- Save evidence — don't delete messages, screenshots, or accounts
- Avoid confronting the other person directly
- Reach out to a trusted professional or your local authorities



## Get Help & Report — Sri Lanka

- NCPA Child Helpline — call 1929 (free, 24 hours, Sinhala, Tamil & English)
- Report images/videos online — NCPA Cyber Crime Division / IWF Sri Lanka Portal at [childprotection.gov.lk](http://childprotection.gov.lk)
- Police Emergency — call 119
- Email NCPA — [complaints@childprotection.gov.lk](mailto:complaints@childprotection.gov.lk)
- IFDC training & resources — [www.ifdchild.org](http://www.ifdchild.org)



**Open, honest conversations keep children safest online.**

**NCPA Child Helpline: 1929 | Police Emergency: 119**

Request an IFDC training for your school, university, or community — [www.ifdchild.org](http://www.ifdchild.org) | [info@ifdchild.org](mailto:info@ifdchild.org)